MADHYA PRADESH

KAMAL NATH'S COLD START DOCTRINE

By Rahul Noronha



The Congress headquarters in Bhopal is a hive of activity—unusual given that the assembly election is only in 2023, and the party unit is used to 'coming alive' only when polls are near. Madhya Pradesh PCC chief and former chief minister Kamal Nath is making an early start, though. Nath, who had finally wrested the state from the BJP in 2018 only to lose it in 2020 when Jyotiraditya Scindia and his cohorts switched sides, knows that strengthening the organisation is crucial to take on the saffron regime, even one enervated by the long stint in power (2003-18 and then from 2020 on).

MP is crucial for the Congress as it is among the few states where the party's been able to stage a comeback, even take the fight to its principal adversary, the BJP. Moreover, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh, the other two Congress-led states going to polls in 2023, could be facing anti-incumbency. A wave in its favour in MP could act as ballast in the other two states.

Part of the reason for the early intervention is Nath's organised style of functioning, and his experience of his home bastion, Chhindwara, which has been a Congress fortress since 1980. So surveys are under way and reports and bios on possible candidates and party functionaries are being prepared. The 75-year-old Nath seems like a man on a mission, more so because he is now the go-to man for the Congress in MP, with few rivals in sight. Scindia's defection has, in that sense, liberated him. Besides being PCC chief, Nath is also leader of the opposition. Those within the Congress who were close to Scindia but did not go to the BJP with him, have now joined Nath's ranks.

Not that things will be easy for Nath. The state unit needs strengthening; many office-bearers left the party with Scindia and there aren't that many younger leaders of promise in the interiors. Recruitment drives to increase party membership will be a key focus area. For Nath, the critical unit of the party is the *mandalam* (sub-block level), something he's learnt from his successes in Chhindwara. To ensure the party organisation reaches the grassroots, the number of *mandalam*s in each block are being increased. The number of district and block committees will also go up, say party sources. There are around 700 blocks currently, and this is likely to go up by around 10 per cent. The creation of more district, block and *mandalam* committees will also enable the party to dispense more posts. "Party workers get a sense of connect and purpose when they are given a post," says a state unit member.

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The 31 assembly byelections since 2020, their results notwithstanding, have ensured that the party organisation has been working continuously. "We began preparations for the 2023 election the moment the 2020 byelections got over. It has been a continuous process since then," says MP Congress general secretary (administration), Rajiv Singh. The party has also been focusing on its various cells and frontal organisations in the state. Nath feels the cells have tremendous reach since they speak to members of the same social group, trade or profession. There are now 31 cells, with some of the new ones looking at consumer protection, rural industries, the physically challenged, senior citizens, NGOs. There's even a cell to take up the grievances of barbers.